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An 'import' from *Amsterdam to Chennai*

The field sport You.Fo is the latest entrant at the playgrounds of Sri Kanyaka Parameswari Arts and Science College for Women in George Town

LIFFY THOMAS

A ring-throwing stick-and-catch field sport, born thousands of miles away in Netherlands as late as 2012 and still obscure, is being played by the teachers at American International School in Taramani. And now students of a city college are at it. Students of Sri Kanyaka Parameswari Arts and Science College for Women got introduced to the new sport recently. You.Fo, as the sport is called, is a mixed-gender, non-contact sport played by throwing an aerodynamic ring with specially designed sticks. Combining the features of lacrosse and ultimate frisbee, the sport can be played on the beach sands, playground or any open space measuring 10 by 30 metres.

Cyril Veronis, media and production specialist at American International School, is the ambassador of this sport in Chennai. He got fascinated with this innovative sport. "Most Wednesdays, we teachers would play this sport that was introduced to us by Giovanni Bello, former aquatics director, who had picked it up from the founders directly," says Cyril.

The fitness enthusiast who plays soccer and is regular with every marathon loved You.Fo for the adrenaline rush it brought.

"Something struck me about this sport. May be the speed as I have taken part in more than 50 marathons and cycling events so



Students of Sri Kanyaka Parameswari Arts and Science College for Women having a go at You.Fo; and (below) Cyril Veronis. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

far and the 10-minute format was easy and fun," says Cyril who is in his late 20s.

He began researching and developed a keen interest in the game, following which Giovanni connected him to the founders. Today, Cyril is playing the role of ambassador and India lead to promote the sport.

"Curious how the game is played competitively, I enrolled for the World Cup last year under the mixed nationality team. This time, the World Cup is scheduled to be held in China in July 2026 and I am keen that India take part in it. The best part is that the

sport can be played with a minimum team size of three and multiple teams can represent a country," says Cyril, who studied mechanical engineering before stints in information technology and graphic designing.

In January, he conducted a boot camp along with Pace & Blaze running club at Ampa Skywalk to promote the sport. "My focus is in targeting schools and colleges as this sport was developed in co-creation with PE teachers and students, so that we can have multiple teams by the time this sport becomes a part of the Olympics," he says.

The equipment including the ring and the sticks are manufactured in India and Cyril is working to see how these kits can be made more affordable for all.

As when frisbee was in its early years, You.Fo needs sponsors and above all a team that will compete in the real spirit of the sport.

Until then Cyril is happy to be invited to other institutions to introduce the game and its techniques and find like-minded students keen on taking up the sport. "It is a growing game and the organisers have been tweaking it to make it more acceptable for all age groups," says Cyril, a resident of Choolaimedu.

To know more about the sport, visit Instagram page youfoindiaofficial or call 9566093802



The origins

Developed by Bas Ruysenaars and Giel Bos, You.Fo is one of the fastest-growing sports worldwide, being played in more than 30 countries. You.Fo has been recognised for its innovative character, winning the Dutch National Sports Innovation Award and the PROFIT European Award for Innovation, says a note on the website. The first World Cup was held in the Netherlands in 2023 (with Japan finishing first, Canada second and the Netherlands third). YOU.FO engages teams to move, play and compete together with people across backgrounds, ages and abilities.

Rich medal haul for Boccia players from TN

K. KEERTHIVASAN

First things first. Boccia is a precision ball sport, the term derived from the Latin word for "boss". It is played by athletes with severe physical disabilities. Recently in Ahmedabad, Boccia Sports Federation of India organised the 10th Senior National Championship in which the Tamil Nadu team consisting of 15 Boccia players bagged four medals under different categories:

Individual Match: S. Dinesh Kumar – silver medal under BC-1 male individual category; M. Mahalakshmi – gold under BC-2 female individual category; and M. Anusuya – bronze under BC-3 female individual category

Pair Match: M. Anusuya & K. Umayya Saravanan – bronze under Mixed BC3 Pairs category.



The Tamil Nadu boccia contingent.

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Speed up SWD work at Adam Street

BASKAR SESHADRI

Greater Chennai Corporation has taken the initiative to construct a storm-water drain network in Adam Street, Mylapore, but the work is progressing at a tardy pace. As

seen in this picture, workers have dumped gravel and sand on both sides of the road shrinking the motorable space.

When cars roll through this stretch, they run over the materials and bring them to the centre which leaves motorcyclists on a di-

cey wicket. As Adam Street is one of the longest stretches providing access to Mandaveli, many motorists choose it over Ramakrishna Mutt Road. GCC should expedite the work.

Baskar Seshadri is a resident of Mylapore

A reminder to pet parents



CIT Colony Residents Welfare Association has launched a civic awareness campaign targeting dog owners across the neighbourhood.

The RWA has installed boards that remind them that they have to clean up after their pets, carrying a poop stick with them.

GCC must be strict in enforcing the fine for not cleaning up



or authorise the RWA to collect it.

Ramdas Naik is secretary of CIT RWA

RA Puram resident bags best coach award



Meenakshi Ganesh receiving the award from Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin.

Fifty-four-year-old Meenakshi Ganesh, who received the Chief Minister's State Sports Award for best coach for the year 2025-26, has been a dedicated table tennis coach since 2012.

A resident of RA Puram, Meenakshi has been mentored by the Rao brothers, Srinivasa and

Muralidhara. As a State-level coach certified by Table Tennis Federation of India's NIS course in 2020, she nurtures young talent from as early as 2.5 years old.

Currently coaching 30 children at Mylapore Sports Trust, Meenakshi has propelled 10 students to the State's top five rankings, with four earning in-

ternational accolades. She also coaches two Paralympic athletes and has accompanied them to international tournaments, demonstrating her commitment to inclusive and high-level coaching. "She used to work with kindergarten students and we used her experience to start training children," said Muralidhara Rao.

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Sketching dreams

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

A desperate father searching for an art class located on the ground floor for his differently abled enthusiastic daughter brought them to Mylai School of Arts in Mylapore two years ago. February 22 will mark an important milestone for 14-year-old S. Parameswari, an aspiring artist from RA Puram. Five of her artworks will be showcased at Oviya Sangamam 2026, a one-day exhibition of artworks of established and upcoming artists from across the country.

Along with Parameswari, 30 other students of Mylai School of Arts in Mylapore are excited to find a platform to showcase their artworks at the same venue. Like her, a majority of them have a heart-warming story.

A Class IX student of Chennai High School in Kannammapet, T. Nagar, Parameswari says she first learnt to draw seeing videos on the phone. Seeing her interest in art, her father, who does painting-related works, set out to search for an institute only to find that most of them were a floor above the



ground with no lift or escalator.

"The interest of this father and daughter is what has amazed me. Parameswari moves around with the help of a wheelchair and the only vehicle her father owns is a two-wheeler where he straps her and picks and drops her to classes every weekend," says K. Kanakaraj, who has been running the academy for the last four years.

He charges a nominal fee from those who can afford the regular fee. "I had waived off the fee from Parameswari but her father insist that I take it for teaching my

How an art school in Mylapore is helping children, some of them from underprivileged communities, express themselves through art



daughter. The two have a lot of dreams through art and I hope I can help them fulfil those dreams with my classes," says Kanakaraj.

Another of his differently abled students R. Ashwanth comes from Nochikuppam. "His father is a fisherman and is often without work

but he encourages his son to come to my classes," he says, adding that he is grateful to Indian Art Factory for giving many aspiring artists a platform. Children of single parents and a few adults are among others finding satisfaction with the brush strokes.

The event

More than 400 artistes will be showcasing their works at Oviya Sangamam 2026 happening at Wings Convention Centre, St. George School campus, Shenoy Nagar on February 22; 9 a.m. to 6 p.m. Organised by Indian Art Factory, this is the third edition of this exhibition-cum-sale where participants from various parts of India would showcase art and crafts works in a variety of mediums and styles. For details, call 8122317518

New park at Demonte Colony opened



BASKAR SESHADRI

Demonte Colony Corporation Park was opened on the evening of February 6 by Mylapore MLA Dha Velu. Ward councillor Malthy was present on the occasion.

On account of the renovation work undertaken using MLA Fund,

the park had stayed shut for one year. It was initially planned as an exclusive park for pets, but taking note of objections raised by many local residents to this plan, it has been made a general park.

Amenities at the park include a play area with play equipment for children and a gymnasium; a drinking water facility; and a rest room for men and women



PHOTOS: SRINATH M AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Children's Club opened

The renovated Jawahar Bal Bhavan (aka Jawahar Children's Club) opposite Ragha Sudha Hall at Luz Avenue in Mylapore, which was closed last year, was opened by Health Minister Ma Subramaniam and South Chennai MP Thamizhichi Thangapandian recently. Mylapore MLA Dha Velu and local councillor Saraswathi Mohan also took part. This children's club opens in

the evening hours, offering a raft of extracurricular activities to children aged below 16 years, drawn from local schools, mainly government and government-aided. Run by the state government, the club offers support for children to specialise in arts and crafts, encouraging them to participate in national-level competitions.

Baskar Seshadri is a resident of Mylapore

Promoting a rare category of student volunteers

With the Board exam season having begun, the need to create a bank of scribes is again being keenly felt



A student appearing for an exam with the help of a scribe. Image used for representational purpose only. PHOTO: PERIASAMY M

LIFY THOMAS

Sharon Rachel Aby's experience of appearing for Class X CBSE Board examinations last year was largely stress-free for two reasons. One, she is academically bright; and two, her school found a junior who was ready to scribe for her in all the six subjects she was taking exams in.

Sharon has Spinal Muscular Atrophy, a rare degenerative disease that restricts hand movement, which means she debilitatingly slow-paced in her writing speed. At Spartan Exclusive School in Mogappair where she studied, she found Akshith of Class IX to scribe for her, and ensured they both had two to three sessions prior to the examinations to understand each other. Sharon scored 92.2% with a centum in French.

For some, finding a scribe can be a straightforward process, but for many students with disabilities

it is a stressful experience, often one that causes them to depend on NGOs and personal networks.

School boards such as Indian Certificate of Secondary Education and Central Board of Secondary Education insist that the candidate can use their discretion in either opting for their own scribe/ reader or requesting the examination centre to provide one. They also insist that the qualification of the scribe be one step below the qualification of the candidate taking the examination.

The rules are different in the School Education Department of Tamil Nadu. Government school teachers are selected by the District Education Office to volunteer as scribes for Class X and XII Board examinations. Earlier, it had planned to appoint interested BED students and Illam Thedi Kalvi volunteers, but that GO was dropped on February 19 after many disability groups objected to limited time in taking up this exercise.

In many cases, candidates who

are homeschooled or writing exams through the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS) have to fend for themselves when it comes to finding a scribe.

E.G. Manikandan, a senior special educator with more than 17 years of experience, helps students with NIOS registration including arranging for scribes. He reaches out to private schools well in advance to help identify student volunteers who then have to go through a scribbling orientation exercise. He says NIOS allows parents and close relatives to act as scribes provided

they are registered and meet certain criteria.

"But the challenge is when the parents are not educated and one has to find a suitable volunteer for scribbling," he says, adding that a CBSE school in Mylapore sent him five students last year to scribe.

Having a pool of scribes who can work with students with varying disabilities, including communication-related problems, will go a long way in creating a more empathetic society and it is within the school system that this can be effectively nurtured.

Inclusive schools

"Finding a scribe in an inclusive set-up is easy, and most schools where we work play an important role in promoting inclusion. For instance, at Little Flower School in Kundrathur, announcement is made during the assembly inviting children to volunteer as scribes. They also give certificates to encourage such students," says Kalpana Kumar, founder, Kare Therapy

Centre.

For students applying to study abroad, she says, mention of any volunteering stint as a scribe or efforts to promote inclusion is a bonus and many schools they work with push this agenda to their students, says Kalpana.

A pool of scribes

For many years now, V. Sivaraman, an associate professor at Presidency College, has been asking the office of the Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities to initiate the creation of a common portal for scribes and students. As most colleges have examinations at the same time, depending on students as volunteer-scribes is not always a reliable option. Sometimes, a volunteer would not want to come every day. Though there are many volunteer groups helping find scribes, the professor thinks a portal from the government that lists the needs of the visually challenged and availability of volunteers would be more sustainable.

Exam schedule

ISC: February 12 - April 6
ICSE: February 17 - March 30
CBSE: February 17 - March 11
CBSE: Class XII - February 17 to April 10
SSLC - March 3 - March 27
Class XII - March 2 - March 26

Ferruginous Pochard sighted near Chennai

A lone Ferruginous Pochard was found among a flock of Common Pochards at Amoor lake near Sirudavoor

PRINCE FREDERICK

A sleepy town can be thrust into the limelight when a motorcade of VIPs roll into it. On the trail of these hallowed wheels, might roll wheels of a lesser god. These are the star-struck seeking a glimpse of the glitterati, the shimmering specks of their stardust flying about in the air. Sometimes, just sometimes, a lone VVIP would have slipped in unnoticed among the motorcade, their identity coming to light only when the motorcade screeches to its final halt at the town.

This scenario is playing out at Amoor lake off Tirupo-



ur-Thirukazhukundram Road. Just a couple of kilometres from Sirudavoor lake, Amoor lake became a destination of choice for birders over the last couple of weeks. The VIPs that have been pulling in wheels from Chennai are a sizeable flock of Common Pochards, a rarity in these parts. The lone VVIP that has heightened the level of interest in this waterbody is a lone Ferruginous Duck

(also known as Ferruginous Pochard) that has tagged along with the flock of Common Pochards. A Ferruginous Pochard is more than a rarity anywhere near Chennai, let alone within it.

On February 14, which is Valentine's Day (in case you are a Flintstone unfamiliar with the ways of the modern world), three birders, Sundarav Palanivel, Sivakumar Shanmugasundaram and Sa-

ravana Manian spotted a female Ferruginous Pochard when they were training their cameras with those incredibly elongated lenses on the flock of Common Pochards. They did not conclude the odd one out was a Ferruginous Pochard straightaway. They posted images of the different-looking duck in bird identification forums, a firm word was out that the bird in question was indeed a Ferruginous Pochard. The record was also up on eBird.

Where the Common Pochard (*Aythya ferina*) and the Ferruginous Pochard (*Aythya nyroca*) are concerned, the females can get mixed up in a birder's head, the female of one species being mistaken for the female of the other. This confusion crops up often as the Common Pochards and the Ferruginous Pochards are both diving ducks that are hugely affable to-

wards each other, hanging out together even when they have flown to their winter destination. And they are also known to take this friendship sometimes to a different level, in other words, ending up as more-than-just-friends. And that takes you to a whole new category called Ferruginous Pochard (Hybrid).

When the Pochard literates in these bird identification groups were peering at the images of the lone Ferruginous Pochard from Amoor lake, they had to consider the possibility of it being a hybrid. That possibility was ruled out without an iota of lingering doubt. The verdict is: Ferruginous Pochard female. And that makes it the second time that this species has been sighted in the Chennai Metropolitan Area; the earlier sighting had happened at the Pallikaranai marsh in 2023, that record is also up on eBird.



Two Common Pochards and (above) a Ferruginous Pochard at Amoor lake on February 14. PHOTOS: SARAVANA MANIAN AND SUNDARAVEL PALANIVEL

Artistes pay tribute to Saint Thyagaraja

Indian Fine Arts Society (IFAS) organised its annual Saint Thyagaraja Aaradhana Day at Ethiraj Kalyana Mandapam in Alwarpet on February 14. The proceedings began with prayers and aarti to the portrait of Saint Thyagaraja, followed by group performance of the Pancharatna Krithis.

About 70 musicians including vocalists, violinists, mridangists, ghatam, morsing, flautists and veena and kanjira vidwans took part in the performance. Some of the renowned artistes included Karur Krishnamurthi, Srimushnam V. Raja Rao, M. Narmada, Jayalakshmi Sekar, Iyer Sisters, Sriranjani Kaushik and Muthukumar.

Office-bearers of IFAS including K.V. Ramachandran, president, K. Venkatraman, vice-president and R. Radhakrishnan, honorary secretary, were present, said a press release.



Workshop on EV technology

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu, is organizing a training programme on electrical vehicle technology from February 24 to 26. Time: From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m.

According to a press release, participants will learn about the science and technology of an electric vehicle. The following concepts will be covered: power electronics, regenerative braking, EV battery fundamentals and battery management system, thermal management in EVs, safety in EVs, EV powertrain operation, performance, efficiency and standards.

For details, call 8668102600 / 8754495254.

Four books released in two launch events



Two recent book release events in the city brought together members of the medical fraternity, literary figures and prominent personalities.

According to a press release, three books that saw the light in one of the events are: *Every Patient is a Narrative*, *The Surgeon in Me (My Autobiography)* and *Dhanya's Diaries*. Authored by Dr. S. Devaji Rao of Chennai Meenakshi Multispecialty Hospital, all the three books

were launched at Hotel Raj Park on TTK Road in Alwarpet, being released by Dr. Sudha Seshayyan, former Vice-Chancellor of Tamil Nadu Dr. MGR Medical University. The first copies were received by Dr. Vaibhav Suresh, Dr. V. Vijayasathya and Dr. Lakshmi Nagarajan.

The event was followed by a talk on "Emerging Trends in Pain Management" delivered by Dr. Sreekumar Raghavan, orthopedic surgeon, who spoke about evolving ap-



proaches and advancements in the field, the press release adds.

Second edition

In another event, *Paamaran Bagavath Geethai*, authored by Sevalaya Muralidharan and published by Vanathi Pathippagam, saw the release of its second edition on February 14, 2026. The book was originally released in June 2024 and was well received.

The second edition was launched at Arkay Convention Center at Luz Corner in Mylapore. M. Murali, managing director of Sri Krishna Sweets, released the

book. Isaikkavi Ramanan, author V. Muralidharan, who is the founder and managing trustee of Sevalaya, along with several prominent personalities, participated in the function, the release adds.

The book is based on *The Bhagavad Gita According to Gandhi* by Mahatma Gandhi, *Srimath Bhagavath Geethai* by Mahakavi Bharathiyar and the lectures of Swami Vivekananda on the Bhagavad Gita. The speciality of the book is that it explains the lessons of the Gita through simple examples from the everyday life of common people.

Soft toy making classes in Mylapore

For more than 50 years, Indira Premkumar, a craftsper-son, has been transforming simple beads and soft fabrics into treasured toys, gifts and memories. Indira conducts classes at her home in Malleswarar Koil Street, Mylapore.

One can learn to make soft toys, customised fabric bags, bead wall hangings, handbags, purses, keychains, and decorative toys, said a press release.



The classes have empowered many women to be financially independent.

For details, call Indira Premkumar at 9176599248, 9445232507.

Temporary changes in train operations

Due to ongoing redevelopment works at Chennai Egmore railway station, the suburban trains scheduled to operate on platforms 10 and 11 (suburban platforms) will run on platforms 5 and 6 till April 5.

During this period, all EMU trains from Chennai Beach to Tambaram, Chen-

galpattu, Kanchipuram, and Arakkonam will run on platform 6

In return, all EMUs to Chennai Beach will run on platform 5. During the block period, all existing suburban train services on the Chennai Beach-Tambaram/Chengalpattu/Arakkonam section will be can-

celled and operated with revised train schedules.

Chennai Beach - Tambaram: 3.30, 8.05, 8.30, 8.45, 9.05, 10, 10.40, 11, 11.15, and 11.45 a.m., 12 noon, 1.20, 2.30, 3.35, 6, 9.05, 11, 11.25, and 11.50 p.m., and 12.05 a.m. For complete details, log on to <https://x.com/DrMChennai>

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Dr. J. Radhakrishnan (second from left) with other dignitaries at the inauguration of the conclave.

Envisioning a future-ready roadmap for Chennai

Citizen-driven insights took centre stage at the Super Chennai Conclave 2026; a series of panel discussions marked the event

The first Super Chennai Conclave 2026 brought together policymakers, industry leaders, entrepreneurs and urban visionaries to translate citizen-driven ideas into an actionable roadmap to strengthen infrastructure, safeguard the coastline, and drive inclusive urban transformation.

Speaking at the inaugural address, Dr. J. Radhakrishnan, Additional Chief Secretary to Government of Tamil Nadu; Chairman and Managing director - TANGEDCO, said: "Sustainability must guide how we design transport, strengthen public health and create economic opportunity. Chennai must lead not by comparison, but by competing confidently on the global stage. That requires alignment between govern-

ment, private enterprise and citizens. When we move together, collective aspiration becomes measurable progress – and that is how we build a benchmark coastal capital for the future."

Ranjeeth Rathod, Managing Director, Super Chennai, said, "The conclave represents the transition from consultation to implementation. Over the past several months, we have engaged with citizens and domain experts to shape a framework that reflects shared priorities for the city's growth. The discussions here reaffirmed the alignment between policy leadership and industry stakeholders. The focus now is on structured follow-through so that the recommendations translate into measurable progress for Chennai."

T R B Rajaa, Minister for Industries, Investment Promotion and Commerce, Government of Tamil Nadu, took part in the conclave. The event saw powerful participation from leaders across sectors, including Arun Vasu, Managing Director, TT Group; Ashwini Asokan, Founder & CEO, Vue.ai (Mad Street Den Inc.); Hari Ganapathy, Co-Founder, Pickyourtrail; Mohamed Ali, President, CREDAI Chennai; Ramkumar Ramamoorthy, Co-Founder & Partner, Catalinc Partners; Raj Cherubal, Executive Director, Chennai Smart City Limited; Sandeep Nanduri, Managing Director, TIDCO; Soundarya Rajesh, Managing Director, Avtar Group; Sivarajah Ramanathan, Mission Director & CEO, Startup TN; Vikram Cota, CEO, GRT Hotels; and Vishesh Rajaram, Co-Founder & Managing Partner, Speciale Invest; and filmmaker Gautham Vasudev Menon.

The day saw discussions centered on key pillars critical to Chennai's transformation – investment and industry growth, urban infrastructure, tourism, technology and innovation, entrepreneurship, sustainability, and inclusive development. The conclave witnessed the participation of over 200 delegates, including policymakers, industry leaders, entrepreneurs, journalists and civic stakeholders, reflecting strong cross-sector commitment to shaping the city's future.

Workshop on mushroom cultivation

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on mushroom cultivation on February 26. Another workshop on making chocolates will be held on February 27.

Both the sessions will be at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048.

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Keep your dry waste ready: ROKA drive coming soon

The collection is happening on February 28 and March 1 at various venues across Chennai

ROKA is organising a 12th dry waste collection drive on February 28 and March 1 (open from 9 a.m. to 4 p.m. on both days). For the two-day drive, ROKA is with SPRECO as its recycling partner

According to a press release, Mangayarkarasi Magalir Mandram in Sastri nagar, Adyar has offered its space for the collection drive without any charges.

The items to be collected are: E-waste; clothes (Usable and unusable; in clean and dry condition only); unbroken glass bottles; toys/ stationery; paper, cardboards and magazines; empty tablet strips; thermocol; metals; footwear; plastic (hard and soft/ MLP plastics). The release notes that

for the items to be collected, they need to be clean and dry.

The venues for the collection drive are as follows:

Mangayarkarasi Magalir Mandram, Sastri Nagar, Adyar; Apex Club, Velachery; Public Gym, Sivagamipuram, Thiruvanniyur; Greater Chennai Corporation park, Dhandayudhapani Nagar, Kotturpuram; Women's India Association, Greenways Road; and New Prince Matriculation Higher Secondary School, Adambakkam (only on Sunday 10 a.m. to 3 p.m.)

Climate action is about conscious consumption and disposal. Those who want to sign up as a volunteer for the drive can call 8667499135.

Two-day online training course on Generative AI

The Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu, is conducting an online training programme on Generative AI from on February 27 and 28. Time: From 6 p.m. to 8 p.m.

According to a press release, the session will cover fundamentals of AI, Machine Learning, Deep Learning, and Generative AI, along with hands-on exposure to Large Language Models. The training will also focus on integrating AI with PDFs, databases, APIs, and tools.

Registration fee is ₹1000. For details, call 9962596111.

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